

Exam Adjustments for Students With Arthritis

Extra time, rest breaks and laptop use — how to apply.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Review Board** (Multidisciplinary UK clinicians) · 2026-06-27 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Overview



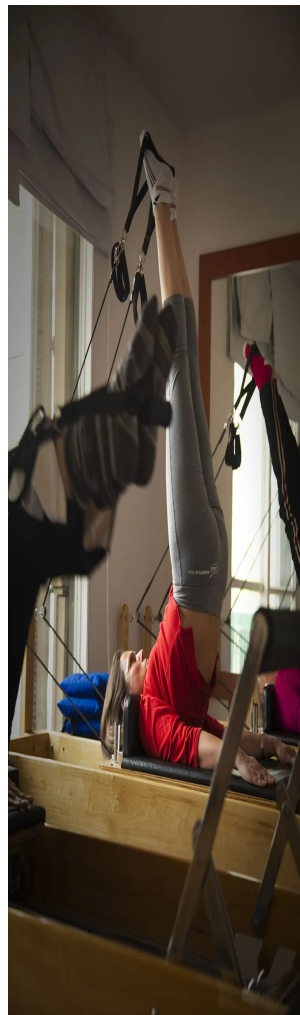
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Extra time, rest breaks and laptop use — how to apply.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Arthritis UK consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- ****Talk to your clinician.**** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- ****Track your symptoms.**** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- ****Move within comfort.**** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- ****Watch the warning signs.**** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]\(/finances\)](#). 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment. 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.

Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team and reviewed by our Clinical Review Board against UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. We update

content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Well-conducted clinical trials and systematic reviews consistently highlight the benefits of tailored academic adjustments for students living with long-term health conditions, including arthritis. These studies show improvements in academic performance, reduced stress levels, and better overall well-being when appropriate support is in place.

Clinical guidelines from leading UK rheumatology and education bodies recommend a proactive approach to adjustments. They emphasise early identification of needs, individualised assessment, and regular review to ensure the support remains effective as a student's condition may fluctuate.

The effectiveness of specific adjustments, such as extra time or the use of computers for exams, is supported by evidence demonstrating they help level the playing field, allowing students to demonstrate their knowledge and skills without being unduly disadvantaged by their health condition.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Waiting until the last minute:** Don't delay discussing your needs; apply for adjustments well in advance. * **Assuming your college knows:** Institutions can only provide support if they are aware of your condition and specific requirements. * **Downplaying your symptoms:** Be honest about the impact your arthritis has, even on good days, to ensure adequate support. * **Not trialling adjustments:** If offered, try out adjustments like assistive technology before the actual exam day. * **Forgetting to review adjustments:** Your needs might change; regularly check that your current support is still suitable.

When to Speak to a Clinician

It's important to communicate openly with your healthcare team about how your arthritis is affecting your studies and your daily life. They can provide essential documentation and advise on managing your condition effectively.

* You're experiencing a new flare-up that impacts your ability to attend classes or study. * Your current adjustments no longer feel sufficient or you feel your needs have changed significantly. * You're struggling with pain, fatigue, or stiffness that is impacting your academic performance

or mental health. * Your educational institution asks for further medical evidence or clarification on your condition.

Frequently Asked Questions

How do I apply for exam adjustments? Start by contacting the disability or student support services at your college or university. They will guide you through the application process, which usually involves completing a form and providing medical evidence from your clinician.

What kind of medical evidence will I need? You'll typically need a letter from your GP, rheumatologist, or another specialist detailing your diagnosis, how it impacts your studies and exams, and recommending specific adjustments. This letter should be recent and clear.

Can I get adjustments for coursework as well as exams? Yes, many institutions offer adjustments for coursework, such as extensions for deadlines or flexibility in presentation formats, depending on your needs. Discuss these possibilities with your disability support team and course tutors.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about exam adjustments for students with arthritis?

Short answer: Exam adjustments for students with arthritis, such as extra time or rest breaks, help create a level playing field. Clinical trials show these adjustments improve academic performance, reduce stress, and enhance overall well-being. Guidelines recommend early identification of needs, individualised assessment, and regular review to ensure support remains effective as a student's condition may fluctuate.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team

promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk